

By Swati Mathur

Like most vegetarians, actor Shama Sikand was forced to live on Pak Choy for several days when she travelled to China. Despite being a foodie, all she could order were variations of the bland Chinese cabbage. Slimmer but wiser, Sikand returned to Mumbai where she met Edward Wang of China Garden and complained about the lack of vegetarian options in her favourite cuisine. Wang, executive chef at the top-rated restaurant, created a special mock meat menu for her and other vegetarians facing the same predicament. The restaurant's mock meat menu, introduced three months ago, has been a runaway success. Says Wang, "Mock meat simulates the texture and feel of meat, but is pure vegetarian." Flavoured soya cakes, for example, which he imports from China, taste a lot like meat.

It's a trend that is catching on across most fine-dining restaurants where restrictive vegetarian menus, comprising mostly tofu and greens, have kept away clients like Sikand and Shahid Kapur, who love eating out but are vegetarian. Innovative new dishes using meat substitutes are finding their way into world cuisine. So now you can have a vegetable or fruit carpaccio or a tempura made out of asparagus. The Japanese have their own version of a meat substitute called tempeh which is becoming increasingly popular as more and more restaurants serving international cuisine create meatless delicacies out of dishes where using meat was the norm. In all cases, the

chefs say retaining the original flavour and giving the customers as authentic a meal as possible is of paramount importance. Carpaccio is an appetiser traditionally associated with meats or fish and recreating the original flavour requires a high level of culinary skill and creativity.

That's in evidence everywhere these days as master chefs are creating a revolution in their kitchens. Whether it is the Portobello mushroom bourguignon instead of the traditional beef, Japanese sushi

with asparagus or dim sums with seaweed, there's no limit to the range of vegetarian equivalents now available. The Trident at Nariman Point in Mumbai for instance, serves Asparagus Cheese Maki (dried and pressed layer sheets of seaweed or algae), Shitake Maki and Inari Sushi, with toppings stuffed into a small pouch of fried tofu that are popular alternatives to their non-vegetarian counterparts. Similarly, an array of vegetarian Maki rolls and Temaki (hand-made rolls) with fillings like

Age of Mock MENUS

Restaurants are expanding their menus with innovative vegetarian versions of traditional meat-based dishes

JAMES BIAKA
This executive chef creates the Japanese specialty Yakitori—skewered chicken in Taki sauce—with shitake for vegetarian regulars at Tetsuma in Mumbai

WIKAN NAMVESIS
The Teppanyaki expert at India Jones, Trident, Nariman Point, whips out vegetarian delights like Shitake Maki rolls and Kushi-yaki from the hotel's kitchen

SHIRYA PATIL SHINDE

MANDAR DEODHAR